How we built 509 M&A opportunities for a UK advisory firm in about 5.5 months

509 live owner and buyer conversations, off-market, on cold email, between 16 February and the end of July 2026. Here is exactly how it was built.

Who we targeted

Direct-to-owner deal origination. We emailed UK business owners to surface exit-ready companies, then handed those conversations to the advisory firm's acquirer network. A second, smaller track signed up UK PE funds as buy-side clients.

- **Geography:** UK only.
- **Companies:** owner-managed SMEs, mostly under 20 employees.
- **Size:** GBP 500k to GBP 5m EBITDA, flexing up to about GBP 20m for specific buyer mandates. Qualified on EBITDA and quality of earnings, not revenue.
- **Sectors:** financial services, industrials, business services, and a range of others. Wealth managers, insurance brokers, MSP and IT, consulting engineers, cleaning, facilities management, freight forwarding and 3PL, infrastructure, mechanical and electrical, food manufacturing, nurseries.
- **Contacts:** up to 2 per company. Owner, Founder, Managing Director, Director, Chairman, and Persons of Significant Control from Companies House. Not President or VP, that is not how UK ownership reads.
- **Buy-side track:** PE fund managers, investment directors, and partners.

The play

Scrape. Two lanes.

- Client-supplied company lists from UK financials databases (Plimsoll, Pomanda), filtered by sector and EBITDA band. Companies only, no people attached.
- We built the contact layer ourselves: Companies House PSC exports, an Apollo core volume list, and a custom sell-intent mining workflow (Exa) that surfaced owners signalling an exit: for-sale, succession, retirement, strategic options. Sell-intent was used to prioritise, never as the only source.

Enrich. Company lists into contactable owners, in Clay.

- Matched company domain and company LinkedIn to the owner or director's own LinkedIn profile.
- Target about 2 contacts per company, roughly 80% match on these small, professional firms.
- Trusted the client's sector tags over AI-guessed ones. Verified every email before send.

Send. On the client's own Instantly account.

- 12 domains, 24 inboxes, 25 sends per inbox per day. About 600 per day of capacity.
- Two sending identities. Tracking off for deliverability. Monday to Friday, 10:00 to 16:00.
- 3-step sequence, 3 to 4 days apart. Step 1 named the buyer, steps 2 and 3 were short follow-ups.
- Non-responders recirculated roughly every 2 months: pull the list, remove anyone who replied, push the rest into a fresh sector-segmented campaign.

The angle that worked

- **Subject line: "Private and confidential."** That is how an owner expects a real acquisition approach to land.
- **We did not open by pitching the advisor.** We named a specific buyer with a specific interest: "we're advising a buyer on acquisitions in {sector}. They expressed specific interest in {company}."
- **CTA stayed low-commitment:** a confidential call to explore.
- **The insight:** one named acquirer with genuine interest beats "we work with buyers in your sector" every time. Owners get the generic version daily. Specificity makes it feel built for them.
- **Follow-ups carried a money angle:** save up to 3% on the deal, or save hundreds of thousands by not going to auction.
- **Buy-side campaign** ran a peer-to-peer, off-market deal-flow angle, with an optional success-fee-only, no-retainer risk reversal.

The numbers

Metric	Result
Active window	16 Feb to end of July 2026, about 5.5 months of sending
Emails sent	~60,000
Unique owners and contacts approached	~19,000
Reply rate	~4% (account level)
Bounce rate	0.4% to 1.9% weekly
Opportunities	509
Prospect to opportunity	~37:1

- One qualified M&A opportunity for every ~37 UK owners contacted. Our internal benchmark across niches sits closer to 1 per 200.
- We reached owner-managed businesses directly and off-market, including owners a prior vendor and the client's own team had not been able to get through to.
- Full build, not just sending: Companies House PSC scraping, Apollo, a custom sell-intent workflow, Clay enrichment down to owner and director level, 12 domains and 24 inboxes stood up and warmed, sector-segmented campaigns, and recirculation every 2 months.

Why the funnel is worth building. Advisory fees run 1% to 2% of deal value, on businesses worth roughly GBP 2m to GBP 10m and up, at sector multiples around 5 to 6 times EBITDA. A single closed deal is worth tens to hundreds of thousands. 509 is the top of that funnel.

The takeaway you can apply

If you sell M&A, PE, or corporate finance, your edge is not volume, it is specificity. Name the buyer. Name the interest. Put it under a subject an owner would actually open in private. Then build the machine that can do that 600 times a day without the copy going generic.